

Titanic reports and evidence

Name _____ Class _____ Date _____

Compare what two newspapers reported in April 1912. A newspaper records a published claim; that claim may be mistaken. Use only the six excerpts below and answer on separate paper.

Source A

The Evening World, New York, April 15, 1912, Final Edition, page 1.
Separate headlines on the same front page. [View original page](#)

A1 “Disabled ship under tow after hitting big iceberg”

A2 “Titanic is reported sinking”

Source B

The Times Dispatch, Richmond, Virginia, April 16, 1912, page 1.
A headline, a message attributed to the steamer Olympic, and the newspaper’s calculation. “Souls” means people; “dispatch” means message. [View original page](#)

B1 Headline: “Of all on board only 675 known to have escaped death in ocean”

B2 From the Olympic message: “Carpathia reached Titanic position at daybreak. Found boats and wreckage only.”

B3 From the same message: “Loss likely to total 1,800 souls.”

B4 Newspaper’s calculation: “Deducting 675, the known saved, would indicate a loss of 1,495 persons.”

Questions worth 10 points

- 1 What change in the reported condition of the ship appears between A and B? Cite one excerpt from each source. (3 points)
- 2 A student writes, “Exactly 675 people survived, and exactly 1,800 died.” Explain why B does not establish either number as an exact final total. Give one reason for each figure and cite the relevant excerpts. (3 points)
- 3 Explain why A1 and A2 are not necessarily contradictory. Then name one thing these excerpts cannot tell you about how A obtained its information. (2 points)
- 4 Write a two-sentence conclusion: one supported statement about the reporting and one question that remains unanswered. Cite an excerpt for the supported statement. (2 points)

Selected excerpts, not complete articles. Excerpt labels are added. Capitalization and line breaks are normalized; line-break hyphenation is rejoined. Each excerpt stands separately.

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Give students page 1 only. Assess how they distinguish published claims from established facts, qualify figures, and recognize limits of evidence. No source search or prior Titanic knowledge is needed. Discuss loss of life sensitively.

Marking guidance for 10 points

Credit accurate paraphrases and score each point independently. An extra unsupported claim affects a point only when it contradicts that point; do not deduct elsewhere. Missing citations affect only explicitly citation-linked credit.

1 Comparing the reporting

- 1 point: describes A's report of a ship under tow or reported sinking.
- 1 point: describes B's report of boats and wreckage at Titanic's position.
- 1 point: makes the change explicit and cites A1 or A2 and B2.

Accept "B indicates the ship had sunk." Do not require a claim that A said everyone was saved; these excerpts do not say that.

2 Qualifying the figures

- 1 point: explains that "known" saved is a reported count, not proof of the final survivor total (B1 or B4).
- 1 point: explains that "likely" marks 1,800 as an estimate (B3), or explains how B4's different conditional calculation leaves the exact death toll unsettled.
- 1 point: cites the relevant excerpt for each explanation.

Credit B4 for the survivor qualification as well as an explained alternative death estimate. Do not treat 1,495 as a verified final toll. No calculation is required.

3 Consistency and missing evidence

- 1 point: a ship could be under tow while sinking, or the headlines could reflect reports received at different times, clearly offered as a possibility.
- 1 point: identifies missing evidence, such as who supplied A's claims, whether that person witnessed events, or when the reports were received.

Do not credit an invented source or an asserted timeline.

4 A supported conclusion

- 1 point: a cautious supported statement with a correct excerpt citation, such as "B printed an estimated loss of 1,800 (B3)."
- 1 point: a genuinely unanswered question, such as the final death toll, why the reports differed, or how A checked its claims before publication.

Accept other conclusions supported by the cited evidence. Neither deliberate deception nor complete accuracy is established by these excerpts.

Sources and provenance

Original pages: [A at the Library of Virginia](#) • [B at the Library of Virginia](#) • [Archive index](#)

Additional Library of Congress records: [A sn83030193 April 15 1912](#) • [B sn85038615 April 16 1912](#)

Scan locations: A1 below the masthead, right half; A2 in the top banner. B1 in the rightmost column; B2 and B3 in its Olympic dispatch; B4 immediately before that dispatch. All six excerpts were visually checked against the original-page scans on October 2, 2026.

The source wording is historical; the questions and guidance are original. This handout has not been classroom-tested. No reading-level, timing, curriculum-alignment, or effectiveness claim is made.